

Blanchard Says He Hopes Yankees Are Ready for Him

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John Blanchard, Yankee catcher from Minneapolis, take the witness stand for your testimony before leaving for spring training:

Q — Are you ready to make it with the Yankees?

A — "I'm ready, but I

don't know whether they're ready for me. They've still got Yogi Berra, you know, and they're not ready to retire him yet."

Q — Do you like the Yanks' organization?

A — "It's great, nice people, but right now it's not doing me any good. People say they're the best in

baseball. How true, they're so good that there's no place for me. Maybe if I was with a second division outfit that needed a catcher I'd have a chance to stay in the majors this season."

Q — How many options do you have left?

A — "I've got one more

option, so I imagine they'll send me back to Denver and then the next season they'll either have to keep me or make a deal for me."

Q — How old are you?

A — "I'm 24. Will be 25 so it's time I should be moving along in this business."

Q — Where did you learn the most in baseball?

A — "At Denver last year, I learned so much catching regularly. When I look back I can see that I didn't know a thing about the game until last season."

Q — Did it help your hitting, too?

A — "Yes, hitting is all in the head. I used to crank up and hit a home run once

in a while, but I didn't have it to be a consistent threat at the plate. Last year at Denver I took on the confidence, which is all you need once you have the God-given gift to swing a bat."

Q — Do you like catching best?

A — "I think it's my spot.

Manager Andy Cohen at Denver tells me I might have a chance to stay with the Yankees because I can also play the outfield and Manager Casey Stengel of the Yanks likes versatility. In the long run, though, I'd probably be better off catching every day at Denver but don't ask me my

choice because I'd have to say the Yankees."

Q — How is your injured ankle?

A — "I took the wrap off in Fargo the other day and took treatments from a Finnish masseur. It feels great, but I'll probably start a little slow in spring training."

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